How To Become a Quality Assurance Tester

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Video: Becoming a Software Tester

Are you interested in a career as a Software Tester but are not sure how to start preparing for it? We have you covered!

KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- Learning more about a quality assurance tester's responsibilities and the steps to become one can help you decide if it is a career you want to pursue.
- A quality assurance tester, or QA tester, works to establish and maintain standards in various professional fields, like software production, video games, digital products, web platforms and communication networks.
- Becoming a quality assurance tester involves a combination of technical education in a specific field and on-the-job training.

Quality assurance testers have an important role in many technical industries. Becoming a quality assurance tester involves a combination of technical education in a specific field and on-the-job training. Learning more about a quality assurance tester's responsibilities and the steps to become one can help you decide if it is a career you want to pursue. In this article, we explain what quality assurance testers do, discuss how to become one and explore the common traits of successful QA testers.

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Source: Indeed Data, US, based on median, compared to job seekers who use mobile app

INSIGHTS FROM INDEED

Quality Assurance Tester Hiring Insights

Average pay

$39.10 / hour

Low $10.25 **High** $86.45

Job seekers

12,824

+22 since August 2026

Employers hiring

145

+145 with open roles this month

Based on Indeed data · Refreshed monthly

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What is a quality assurance tester?

A quality assurance tester, or QA tester, works to establish and maintain standards in various professional fields, like software production, video games, digital products, web platforms and communication networks. They are also in charge of finding flaws, tracing error sources and problem-solving independently and in QA teams. In this capacity, they also work closely with developers to improve the functionality, effectiveness and productivity of the workplace as well as the quality of the product.

Quality assurance testing is sometimes confused with quality control testing, but the two differ significantly. Quality control refers to the process of detecting flaws in products that have already been manufactured and services delivered to customers. In comparison, quality assurance involves the internal developmental process of products and services before they are released to the public.

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What does a QA tester do?

A QA tester is responsible for monitoring all phases of designing and implementing a product to ensure company standards are met. Their role improves the development process by increases effectiveness and quality and catching problems early on. They are also expected to relay issues and feedback between developers, QA teammates and clients. A quality assurance tester's specific duties can be diverse and dependent on the particular project they are assigned. Here is a general list of their most commonly performed duties:

- Designing test plans
- Documenting test progress and results
- Calculating risk
- Writing code for automated tests
- Finding software bugs and glitches
- Setting quality standards
- Designing procedures for product testing
- Performing manual testing
- Researching new testing processes and technologies
- Understanding and analyzing product features
- Driving efficiency and innovation
- Identifying and isolating errors and failures
- Reviewing user interfaces and feedback

There are various kinds of testing suited to different projects, but an experienced QA tester should be proficient in them all. These types of quality assurance tests include:

- Usability testing
- Performance testing
- Compatibility testing
- Security testing
- Load testing
- Functionality testing
- Regression testing

Related: Quality Assurance Skills: Definition and Examples

How to become a QA tester

Follow these steps to pursue a career as a quality assurance tester:

1. Enroll in college

Consider the qualifications required for the industry you'd like to work in to figure out which type of degree or certification you need to earn. Most software quality assurance tester positions require a minimum of an associate degree and recommend a bachelor's degree to be a competitive candidate. Research the accredited institutions near you that offer the qualifications you need. Many provide statistics on their graduation rates and employment rates after graduation that can help you decide where to enroll.

2. Complete your education

It's important to choose a good major if you want to become a QA tester. Consider which industry you want to work in, and choose a relevant major from that field. For example, if you want to work as a software tester, consider getting a bachelor's degree in computer science, engineering or math.

While you're in school, keep in mind that this is an excellent opportunity to network and earn qualifications. Networking with your classmates and instructors is important for future employment and collaboration opportunities.

3. Consider an internship

An internship is a program used to give students and new graduates professional learning experience with employers in their field. Some positions may be paid, while others are unpaid, and they can last anywhere from a few months to a year. Internships are a good opportunity for new QA testers to build their resumes and try out their skills in a given industry.

4. Apply for jobs

After meeting all educational requirements and gaining some experience, you can apply for open quality assurance testing positions. Look for job openings in an industry that interests you and matches your qualifications. Craft your resume and cover letter with the job description for each position in mind to make them feel personalized. To find openings and professional recommendations, make sure to interact with your professional network. If you receive multiple job offers, you can narrow them down based on where you want to live and what each employer offers in regard to salary and benefits.

Related: Quality Assurance Job Description and Position Overview

Average salary for a QA tester

Quality assurance testers' salaries vary based on several factors, including education and experience. Your pay rate may also depend on the business's location and the specific industry you're in. For example, security software QA testers tend to make more than video game quality assurance testers.

The national average salary for quality assurance testers in the United States is $53,688 per year. You may receive some common benefits in this position as well, including health insurance, paid time off, remote work options, referral programs, visa sponsorships, in-office quality-of-life perks and a 401(k) retirement package.

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Common quality assurance tester traits

Here are some skills and traits that can benefit you as a QA tester:

Attention to detail

The ability to focus on details ensures overall productivity, performance, efficiency and client satisfaction. Attention to detail is a learnable skill that you can improve by eliminating distractions, practicing observational skills and focusing on organization.

Organization

Organizational skills refer to the ability to create structure and order. Practicing organizational skills can improve your productivity and efficiency in the workplace.

Listening skills

QA testers benefit from being able to comprehend, remember and implement instructions and standards that supervisors give them. Listening effectively is also an important aspect of communication among peers and subordinates.

Communication

It is not uncommon for quality assurance testers to work in teams and be required to interact with colleagues, supervisors, engineers, developers and clients. This communication may be written or verbal. The ability to discuss errors and problems tactfully is very beneficial.

Problem-solving skills

Quality assurance testers identify errors at work and are often tasked with finding the source of a problem and developing a solution. Being able to problem-solve independently and collaboratively is crucial in this position.

Deductive reasoning

Deductive reasoning is a type of logical thinking that focuses on forming answers or conclusions using factual statements or evidence. A common example of deductive reasoning is if-then statements, which are used widely in technological industries.

Time management

Depending on the problems encountered, a quality assurance tester's time requirements can vary unexpectedly. They are also commonly required to meet strict deadlines. Being able to plan and allocate time effectively is crucial to a QA tester's ability to perform their duties.

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